

From Passion to Prosperity: Strengthening an Entrepreneurial Journey through Financial and Digital Literacy

Happy Ji from **Shimla, Himachal Pradesh** has shown that one can create a stable livelihood source from converting a hobby into a business. She started her entrepreneurial journey in 2009 in the field of knitting and stitching. Apart from her own business, she manages to be an active member of an NGO working in the area of reduction of plastic waste, wherein she creates awareness amongst the community about the dos and don'ts of plastic waste management. Her commitment towards both entrepreneurship and societal welfare shows responsible human behaviour.



Since she had started in 2009, she managed the business well but struggled for its expansion because of limited financial resources and lack of understanding about business expansion strategies. In the early stages of her journey she was having a manually operative knitting machine which confined her capacity to produce. But her aspiration to become independent financially and not being dependent on others encouraged her to continue even after facing the hardships. She purchased the motorized knitting machine with the financial assistance received through the National Rural Livelihood Mission (NRLM) which made her increase the production capacity as well as operations of the business.

The significant role behind the entrepreneurial journey of Happy ji was played by her family. Her inlaws, Husband who himself works as a driver, the block administrative staff motivated her to

continue walking on the path of entrepreneurship. This constant support acted as a strength towards her success now. This support made her feel confident about being an entrepreneur and financially independent as well.

The Training of Financial and Digital literacy gave her a new perspective regarding the calculation of costs of the product. Earlier she calculated only the basic expenses involved in making of the product, but ignored various other important costs. After attending the training she got a better understanding about business costing, and realized that product cost must also include the value of her own time as well along with direct and indirect costs. This made her product pricing decision much better than before. She was also hesitant to use Digital payment applications such as Google pay, but after attending the training she understood about the online financial transactions well, overcame her fear and became digitally literate. At present, she confidently performs the digital transactions for her business. Apart from this, she also became aware of the mechanism of becoming an online seller at various online selling platforms such as ONDC, Meesho, Amazon etc. She understood the importance of using such online marketplaces to reach out to the broader customer base and being able to become more than just a local seller. Beyond gaining the technical knowledge, she now feels more confident about being encouraged to boost her business. She is now well equipped with financial mechanisms and digital tools.

Today, Happy Ji is continuing to lead her business and motivate other women to become financially independent. Her story reflects that financial support, family motivation can empower women entrepreneurs to a great extent and also boosts their confidence.